Lesson 40: Pronouns

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 4: Words, Word Order and the Essay

Adapted from Building Academic Writing Skills by Lin Cui, Harper College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): Unit 17 Pronouns.

In this lesson

You review personal, indefinite (everyone, something) and demonstrative (this, that, these, those) pronouns. You practise noun-pronoun agreement and five rules that prevent common pronoun errors, with texts about population, the census and migrant workers. Correct pronouns make academic writing concise and easy to follow.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Choose the correct subject, object, reflexive and possessive forms.
- Use singular verbs and pronouns with indefinite pronouns such as "everyone" and "something".
- Use "this", "that", "these" and "those" for a noun or for an idea just mentioned.
- Make every pronoun agree with its noun in number and gender.
- Correct common errors such as "my neighbors they", "me and my cousin" and "their / they're".

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
pronoun	a word that represents (replaces) a noun	it, they, everyone, this
subject pronoun	a pronoun used as the subject, usually before the verb	**They** live in different parts of the globe.
object pronoun	a pronoun after a verb or a preposition	We were very proud of **her**.
reflexive pronoun	a -self / -selves pronoun that refers back to the subject; "by" + reflexive means "without help"	Children like to try out new things by **themselves**.
possessive adjective	a word before a noun that shows who owns it	he brought **his** whole family
possessive pronoun	a pronoun that replaces "possessive adjective + noun"	His company hires more foreign workers than **ours**.
indefinite pronoun	a pronoun for people, things or ideas in general	everyone, something, nobody
demonstrative pronoun	this, that, these, those	**That** is hard work for him.
noun-pronoun agreement	a pronoun matches its noun in number (singular / plural) and gender	my niece → her

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
census	an official count of all the people in a country	Many countries conduct a census every five to ten years.
concise	clear, without unnecessary words	Pronouns make the language more concise.
awkward	unnatural, uncomfortable	Repeating "he or she" can be awkward.
conduct	have, perform, do	Does your native country conduct a census regularly?

Rules and explanations

Personal pronouns

	Subject	Object	Reflexive	Possessive adjective	Possessive pronoun
singular	I, you, he, she, it	me, you, him, her, it	myself, yourself, himself, herself, itself	my, your, his, her, its	mine, yours, his, hers, (none for "it")
plural	we, you, they	us, you, them	ourselves, yourselves, themselves	our, your, their	ours, yours, theirs

- **Subject pronoun**: the subject, usually before the verb. "There are many people in the world. **They** live in different parts of the globe."
- **Object pronoun**: after a verb or a preposition. "We celebrated **it** with a big party." "We were very proud of **her**."
- **Reflexive pronoun**: refers back to the subject. "My niece was able to feed **herself** at ten months old." With "by" it means "independently": "Children like to try out new things by **themselves**."
- **Possessive adjective** + noun: "**her** new life".
- **Possessive pronoun**: replaces "possessive adjective + noun" already mentioned. "Now, **hers** has more than **mine**." (hers = her country; mine = my country). Also: "a friend of **mine**".

Indefinite pronouns

- For people: everyone, everybody, anyone, anybody, someone, somebody, no one, nobody. Use them like "he" or "she".
- For things and ideas: everything, anything, something, nothing. Use them like "it".
- They are singular, so the verb and the other pronouns are singular: "Everyone **is** doing **his/her** best for the family."
- Repeating "he or she" can be awkward, so writers often use a plural noun instead: "All people are doing their best for the family."

- In this book's exercises, use "his/her" or a plural noun. (Many style guides today, including APA style, which psychology uses, also accept "they / their" for one person, as in "Everyone should report their information". Follow your teacher's rule.)

Demonstrative pronouns

	Close by	Far away
singular	this	that
plural	these	those

- "Joe went on two short trips with his family. **Those** were happy trips."
- "This" and "that" can also mean the idea or situation just mentioned: "Joe had not been home for two years. **That** was hard for the family." (That = the situation that Joe had not been home for two years.)

Noun-pronoun agreement

A pronoun must match the noun it refers to:

- in **number**: singular noun → singular pronoun; plural noun → plural pronoun.
- in **gender**: masculine (he, him, his), feminine (she, her) or gender-neutral (it, its, they). "My uncle ... **he** brought **his** whole family." "They love the U.S. for **its** better educational and career opportunities."

Five more rules

1. Do not add a pronoun after the subject. Wrong: My neighbors they migrated to the U.S. last year. Right: My neighbors migrated ...
2. Do not use "me and my ...". Wrong: Me and my cousin live in the same city. Right: My cousin and I live in the same city. Our grandparents visit my cousin and me every year.
3. If a pronoun is confusing, write the noun. "Sanjay told Guang that he was happy about his job." (Who is "he"?) Clear: "Sanjay was happy about Guang's job, and he told him so."
4. Change the pronouns in reported speech so the meaning is logical. Wrong: He said that you should check them online. Right: He said that I should check them online. / He said, "You should check them online."
5. Do not confuse: they're (they are) ≠ their; you're (you are) ≠ your; it's (it is) ≠ its. "**It's** 100 miles away from home." "**Its** location is not convenient, but **its** salary is good."

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
>
> - Arabic has no neuter "it": every noun is masculine or feminine. In English, use "it" (or "they" for plurals) for things, ideas and organizations: "The Worldometer is an organization ... **It** provides real time statistics."

- Arabic adds a pronoun inside relative clauses ("the book that I read it"). English does not use extra pronouns: "the book that I read"; "My neighbors migrated ..." (not "My neighbors they migrated").

Practice

Exercise 1. Which noun? Which noun does each pronoun in bold refer to? Give only one noun. (From "Migrant Workers" in your lesson material.)

Example: When people go to another city or country to look for work, **they** become migrant workers. (they = people)

1. Some workers bring their families with **them**, and most of them send money back home.
2. Those workers were out of **their** home country for at least 12 months.
3. The Organization publishes reports on labor issues all over the world. According to one of **its** reports, ...
4. 48% of all international migrant workers are women, and **their** wages are useful to help support their family.
5. By working, these women are helping **themselves**, their families, and the global economy.
6. However, when mothers leave their city or country to work, the situation is hard on **their** children.
7. Even though most mothers send money home, and **it** is used for food and clothing, ...
8. Some of the children even have to live all by **themselves**.

Exercise 2. Pronoun or verb? Choose the correct pronoun (1-3) or verb (4-6).

1. On the one hand, the worker can have an income and help the family. _____ (He/She, They) sends money back home.
2. On the other hand, migrant workers usually have a hard life, especially in the beginning, because _____ (he/she, they) are far from home.
3. Everyone back home also misses _____ (his/her, their) loved ones working far away.
4. If something _____ (happen, happens) to a migrant worker, the family is also affected.
5. Migrant workers _____ (contribute, contributes) to the ups and downs in the population.
6. The population of a city includes everyone. Anyone in the city _____ (is, are) included.

Exercise 3. True or false? Are the words in bold correct? Write True or False, and correct the false ones.

1. Some countries conduct a census every ten years. **These are** important for everyone.
2. The census also shows population changes. It is important for a country to know **that** in order to have appropriate policies.
3. According to the 2020 US Census, there were over 331 million people in the U.S. **This** made the U.S. the third largest country in the world by population.
4. Today, there are about over 74.1 million people under age 18 and 56.4 million people age 65 and older. Ten years later, there will almost be as many old people as there are young ones. **These**

mean that the U.S. is getting older.

Exercise 4. Fill in the pronouns. In your lesson material, complete "Population Changes" (Exercise 4) with seven pronouns.

Exercise 5. Edit a paragraph. There are six more pronoun errors (not counting the example). Find and correct them.

What about Other Countries? A census helps a country know how many people there are and how policies can be adjusted to best serve ~~it~~ (them). The U.S. it is not the only country that has a census every ten years. Other countries such as China and Thailand do the same. Some countries like Japan and Canada they have a census every five years. Whether in our native country Thailand or in the U.S., me and my family participate in the census every time it happens. My parents always say that you should not miss any census because the government will use it's results to better manage the country. My parents are model citizens. Their always doing their best.

Exercise 6. Choose the pronoun. In your lesson material, complete "Foreign-Born Workers" (Exercise 6): five blanks after the example. ("x" means no word.)

Exercise 7. Fill in the pronouns. In your lesson material, complete "A Party for Yuko" (Exercise 7): 14 blanks.

Exercise 8. Edit a paragraph. In your lesson material, read "Teaching English Overseas" (Exercise 8). Find and correct six more pronoun errors (not counting the example, He → They).

Speak with your tutor

- "Check my answers to the Pretest in the lesson material and explain each mistake."
- "Ask me five questions about my family members and where they live. Correct my pronouns, especially he / she / it and his / her / its."
- "Give me ten sentences with blanks for they're / their, you're / your and it's / its. Then check my answers."
- "Here is my paragraph: [paste]. For every pronoun, tell me which noun it refers to, and show me any pronoun that is unclear or does not agree with its noun."

Read aloud

"They're" and "their" sound the same, and so do "it's" and "its". Check the spelling when you write.

- My cousin and I live in the same city.
- Our grandparents visit my cousin and me every year.
- Children like to try out new things by themselves.
- The computer and medical fields provide a lot of employment. They're very popular among migrant workers.
- The job application has started. You're welcome to apply.
- Its location is not convenient, but its salary is good.

Writing task

Write a paragraph of 150 to 200 words on one topic from Exercise 9:

- What do you think of leaving home to work in a far-away city or country? What would be the advantages and disadvantages for you and your family?
- Does your native country conduct a census regularly? If so, how often? How are the census results used?

Include a title, a topic sentence, supporting ideas with details, and a concluding sentence. Use subject, object, possessive and reflexive pronouns, at least one indefinite pronoun (everyone, someone...) and one "this" or "that" for an idea.

Self-editing checklist:

- Every pronoun clearly refers to one noun and agrees with it in number and gender ("it" for things and organizations).
- Indefinite pronouns have singular verbs and pronouns (or I used a plural noun).
- No extra pronoun after a subject ("my parents they").
- "My family and I", not "me and my family".
- they're / their, you're / your and it's / its are spelled correctly.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- World population clock (used in the Pretest and Exercise 4): https://www.worldometers.info/world-population/
- U.S. and World Population Clock (Exercise 9, topic 4): https://www.census.gov/popclock/

Answer key

Exercise 1 (book)

1. workers 2. workers 3. Organization 4. women 5. women 6. mothers 7. money 8. children

Exercise 2 (book)

1. He/She 2. they 3. his/her 4. happens 5. contribute 6. is

Exercise 3

1. False (book). This (or: That) is important for everyone. (It refers to "a census", which is singular.)
2. False (book). ... to know **those** (or: these, them) in order to have appropriate policies. (It refers to "population changes", which is plural.)
3. True (book).
4. False (book). **This means** (or: That means) that the U.S. is getting older. (It refers to the situation in the sentence before.)

Exercise 4 (book) his, themselves, them, It, That (or This), They, it

Exercise 5

1. The U.S. it is not → The U.S. is not
2. Japan and Canada they have → Japan and Canada have
3. me and my family participate → my family and I participate
4. say that you should not miss → say that we should not miss (or: say, "You should not miss any census ...")
5. it's results → its results
6. Their always doing → They're (They are) always doing

Exercise 6 (book)

1. This 2. he/she 3. him/her 4. x (no pronoun: "foreign-born workers are less likely ...") 5. their

Exercise 7 (book) They, me, It, her, We, herself, his or her, us (or everyone), me, my, she, we (or everyone), us (or everyone), we (or everyone). (The book spells the name both "Yuko" and "Yoko"; it is the same person.)

Exercise 8

1. where their living → where they're (they are) living
2. Its also → It's (It is) also
3. when their overseas → when they're (they are) overseas
4. if someone accepts the job, they must → he or she must
5. directly by himself → directly by themselves ("Some Americans" is plural)
6. If anyone is interested ..., they can → he or she can

(In 4 and 6, the book follows the rule "indefinite pronoun = he/she". APA style would also accept "they".)

My notes